

A RECKONING AND RITUAL WORKBOOK

The Quiet Money Workbook

Ray's one honest sitting and a fifteen-minute Sunday ritual



Find the leaks in one sitting. Then open the bank app
without the knot in your stomach.

“Rich is quiet.”

RAY, 71, RETIRED PLUMBER

What's in Here

One sitting, seven rules, twelve Sundays, and the back of the shed.

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START HERE

Tonight	Read pages 3 to 9, and take your first reading on page 5.
This week	Give one evening to the Leak Hunt, page 10.
This Sunday	Your first Sunday Sums, page 29. Then every Sunday after.

A Letter from Ray

Now then,

I'll tell you something I don't tell many people. In January 1983 we couldn't pay the gas bill. And I was a plumber. I spent all day keeping other people's heating going, and I came home to a house where we couldn't pay for ours.

That bill sat on the mantelpiece for a fortnight. I didn't open it. I think I thought if I didn't look, it wasn't real. It was real. It was also, when Maureen finally opened it, smaller than the thing I'd built up in my head. They always are.

So if you've got envelopes you're not opening, or an app you can't look at, or you get to the end of every month and think, where did it all go: you're not daft, and you're not the worst. Everyone thinks their mess is the worst one. Everyone's wrong. Skint isn't a character flaw. It's a maths problem, and maths problems can be done.

Here's what this book is. One honest sitting, done once, where we find out where it all goes. I call it the Leak Hunt. Then fifteen minutes every Sunday, with a brew, for good. That's Sunday Sums. In between, there are seven rules that have kept me right ever since.

There's no secret in here, and no lads in gilets telling you what to buy. Maureen and I paid off a two-up two-down by the time I was forty-one, on a plumber's wage, and the only clever thing I ever did was write it all down and look at it every Sunday.

Kettle on. Let's have a look.

Rich is quiet.

Ray

P.S. You'll want a pencil, not a pen. You'll see why.

Why This Works

No secret. Four plain habits, and what's actually known about them.

I'll be honest with you: I didn't read any research before I started. I was skint and I had a pencil. But our Kelly looked some of it up for me, and it turns out ordinary habits have a fair bit behind them. Here's what's known, as plain as I can put it, with nothing made up.

1 Looking, instead of not looking

Economists have a name for not checking your money when you suspect the news is bad: the ostrich effect. Research has found people really do tend to look at their accounts less when they're worried. So if you've been avoiding the bank app, you're not daft. You're normal. The Leak Hunt gets you looking once, properly, with a brew, so it stops being a thing you dread.

2 Writing it down

Research on habits keeps finding that people who keep track of something, whether it's food, steps or spending, tend to notice more and change more than people who don't. Nobody's quite sure how much is the writing and how much is the noticing it forces. I don't mind which. In my house it's both.

3 Same time, same place

Habits tend to stick when they're tied to something you already do, at the same time and in the same place. That's why Sunday Sums comes after Sunday dinner. One well-known study found new habits took around two months, on average, to start feeling automatic, and some people a lot longer. Twelve weeks gives you a fair run at it.

4 A gap before buying

A good deal of research suggests that when paying feels effortless, by a tap or a saved card, people tend to spend more than when they have to stop and count it out, though how much more varies from study to study. The Thirty-Day Wait puts the stopping back in.

WHAT THIS BOOK ISN'T

It isn't financial advice, debt advice or advice about your own situation. It doesn't recommend any product, provider or investment. It won't tell you where to keep your money, and it can't promise you'll save any particular amount, because nobody honest can. What it will do is show you where your money goes, and give you fifteen minutes a week to keep it that way. If things are serious, page 9 has free, proper help, and using it is the strong move.

Your Money Calm Score

Take a reading before you touch anything. You'll take it again after Week 12.

In my trade, you never start on a system till you've checked the pressure. Same here. Score yourself honestly, out of ten, on the three things below. Nobody's going to see this but you. In twelve weeks you'll be glad you did it, because you'll have something to compare against that isn't just a feeling.

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

1 I'd rather put my arm down a blocked drain.

10 I'd open it with a brew and not flinch.

OUT OF 10, TODAY	MY SCORE
How calm I feel when I open the bank app	
How well I know where my money goes	
How well I sleep without money on my mind	

Today's date: _____

A NOTE TO ME, TWELVE WEEKS FROM NOW

What do you hope will be different? What are you worried about? Write it like a letter. Nobody reads it but you.

You'll take the reading again on page 42, after Week 12. Every Sunday page has a calm score too, so you'll see it move week by week.

What to Expect

So nothing catches you out. Especially week three.

Every job has a bit in the middle where you wonder why you started. Knowing it's coming is half of getting through it. Here's how the next twelve weeks tend to go.

- The first forty minutes of the sitting** ○ **Awful, probably.** Opening the envelopes is the worst bit. It always looks worse in the envelope than it does on the table.
- The rest of the sitting** ○ **Better, once you're adding up.** Numbers are calmer than worries. You might feel daft about a drip or two. Don't. Write it down and move on.
- The day after** ○ **Lighter.** Maybe a bit cross with yourself. Let that go. You did the hard bit, and plenty of people never get that far.
- Sundays one and two** ○ **New, and a bit fiddly.** You'll not know which row something goes in. Pick one and stick with it. Nobody's marking it.
- Week three** ● **Boring.** This is where most people stop. Boring is the point: boring means nothing's leaking. There's a letter waiting for you after Week 3, on page 32.
- Weeks four to eleven** ○ **Mostly quiet.** You'll miss one at some point, and page 7 covers that. You'll start noticing things before Sunday too: at the till, in the app, at the coffee you were about to buy without thinking.
- Week twelve** ○ **Take the reading again.** Read the note you left yourself, and decide what you're keeping. Page 42.

None of this is a promise. Some people find a lot of leaks, and some find their money was going exactly where it had to. Both are worth knowing.

If You Miss a Sunday

You will. Everyone does. Here's the rule.

**No catching up. No doubling up.
Just do this Sunday.**

I've missed Sundays. Christmases, a funeral, the week our Lisa got married, and a flu in 1999 I'd not wish on anyone. The notebook didn't mind. I just did the next one.

Here's what you don't do. You don't sit down and try to do three weeks at once. You don't go back and fill the gaps in from memory. And you don't decide you've failed and stop. That's how a drip becomes a flood: not the missing, the giving up after.

Missed one Sunday?

Leave that page blank. Gaps are honest. Do this Sunday, on the next page.

Had a bad week and spent a lot?

Write it down anyway, all of it. That's the whole job. Nobody's keeping score but you, and you're on your own side.

Lost the book?

Any notebook. Write "last week's money" at the top and carry on.

Missed a month?

Same again. Turn to the next blank page and do this Sunday. Don't do the month.

Never managed the full Leak Hunt?

Do the Twenty-Minute Leak Hunt on page 43, and start Sunday Sums this week anyway. The full sitting will keep.

Missed so many you've lost count?

Still this Sunday. It's always this Sunday.

PLAN FOR IT NOW, WHILE YOU'RE KEEN

If I miss one, the thing that will get me back to the table next Sunday: _____

Where this book lives, so I always know where it is: _____

A missed Sunday is a drip, not a burst pipe. The notebook's a record, love, not a court case.

Make It Fit Your Life

The book's built one way, and your life might be built another. Here's how to bend it without breaking it.

If you share money with someone

Maureen and I have done Sunday Sums together since 1983, and it's lasted because it's a job for two, not a judgement on one.

- Do the Leak Hunt together if you can. Each of you brings your own statements, and your own drips are yours to own.
- Write amounts, not verdicts. Nobody's spending gets read out in a voice.
- Split the rows. One of you does the shopping, the other the pipework. Swap if you like.
- Each of you gets a Friday Fish, and nobody asks what the other spent theirs on.
- Keep your money separate? Do your own Sunday Sums, then five minutes together on the shared bills.

WHEN IT ISN'T A BUDGETING PROBLEM

If someone controls your money, takes your wages, runs up debt in your name or won't let you see the accounts, a workbook can't fix that, and it isn't your fault. It has a name, economic abuse, and there's free, confidential help. **UK:** the National Domestic Abuse Helpline, 0808 2000 247, free, day or night. **US:** the National Domestic Violence Hotline, 1-800-799-7233. **Elsewhere:** your local domestic abuse service. If you're in danger right now, call the emergency services.

If your income goes up and down

Plumbing work comes in lumps: three boilers one week, a washer the next. Gig work, commission, seasonal work and working for yourself are the same, only more so.

- In the Leak Hunt, plan on your lowest month. Not your average, and never your best.
- On Sundays, "came in" means money that's in the account, not money that's on its way.
- In a good week, pay the future first, and pay it a bit more. The lean weeks are what it's for.
- Self-employed? Put a share of every payment aside for tax before it starts to feel like yours. Ask your tax office or a free advice service how much.

If there's very little coming in

If there's nothing left to cut, this book won't magic money up, and I'll not insult you by telling you to skip a coffee you're not buying. Use it to see clearly, and to make sure nothing's leaking that doesn't have to. Check you're getting everything you're entitled to: in the UK, Citizens Advice can help you check for benefits and grants, and elsewhere your local advice service can. And keep the Friday Fish, even if it's a bag of chips. It's what stops a budget snapping.

Make It Fit Your Life

If there's debt, and what to do when it's got teeth.

If there's debt

Priority debts first, whatever else you choose. The free debt charities say to deal first with the debts where falling behind costs you most: your home, your heating, and anything that can end up in court. Then the rest. For the rest, pay the minimum on everything, then put anything extra on one debt at a time. There are two honest ways to choose which:

SMALLEST BALANCE FIRST

Clear the smallest debt, then roll what you were paying on it into the next smallest. Quick wins, and quick wins keep people going.

HIGHEST INTEREST FIRST

Aim the extra at the debt with the highest interest rate. It usually costs less overall, but the first win can take longer to come.

Both work, and both beat doing nowt. Pick the one you'll stick to, and don't swap every month. I'm not picking for you. It's your pipework.

My school: ☐ Smallest balance first ☐ Highest interest first

My priority debts, if I have any (home, heating, anything heading to court):

Written at the top of my What's Owed page, page 17, on: _____

When it's got teeth

If you're behind on your rent, mortgage, energy or local tax, if you're borrowing to pay bills or other debts, if letters are coming from collectors or a court, or if money keeps you awake most nights: ring free, impartial debt help this week. Even a good plumber doesn't fix a burst main on his own. He shuts it off and rings for help. That's the strong move, not the failure. They're free, they're not lenders, and they've heard worse than yours.

UK

MoneyHelper, moneyhelper.org.uk
StepChange, stepchange.org
Citizens Advice, citizensadvice.org.uk

US

A nonprofit credit counsellor
through the NFCC, nfcc.org

Elsewhere

A free, not-for-profit debt
advice service near you

Good debt advice is free. Be wary of anyone who charges you for it, or who rings you first. If money worries ever make you feel you can't go on, talk to someone tonight: Samaritans on 116 123 (UK and Ireland), or call or text 988 (US).

Part One

The Leak Hunt

One honest sitting. Kettle on. You only ever do it once.

“When I find a leak, I don’t start fixing. I turn the water off and I look.”

Money’s like water, love. It always goes somewhere. The trouble is never that it’s gone. It’s that you don’t know where. So this is one sitting, one evening, where we find out: every statement, every little drip, and next to every outgoing, one question. *Would I buy this again today?*

You’re not fixing anything tonight. Tonight’s for looking. The fixing comes after, and it’s easier than you’d think, because by then you’ll know which pipe it is.

HOW THE SITTING WORKS

Give it an evening. Two to three hours for most people, with a brew at half time. If you have to stop, stop at the end of a step, and finish the same day if you can.

Pencil, not pen. You’ll get things wrong. Everyone does.

Write amounts, not verdicts. Nobody gets told off in this book. Not even you.

Nothing new goes out tonight. No shopping, no “just having a look”. That’s the stopcock.

THE EIGHT STEPS

1	Find the Stopcock <i>get it all on the table</i>	11
2	The Mains <i>what comes in</i>	12
3	The Pipework <i>what goes out on a schedule</i>	13
4	The Drips <i>subscriptions and plans</i>	14
5	The Small Leaks <i>the forty little things</i>	15
6	The No Pile <i>what you’ll do about each No</i>	16
7	What’s Owed <i>the pressure in the system</i>	17
8	The Pressure Reading <i>the sums, and your first Sunday</i>	18

Not up to a whole evening yet? Do the Twenty-Minute Leak Hunt on page 43 first, and come back to this when you’re ready. It’ll keep.

Find the Stopcock

Get everything on the table, and open what you've been leaving face down.

First job on any leak is finding the stopcock. Every house has one, and most people don't know where theirs is till the kitchen's an inch deep. Here, the stopcock is the pile: every statement, every letter, every app, all on the table, so nothing's hiding and nothing new goes out while you look.

Then the envelopes. I've never met an envelope that got smaller for being left on the mantelpiece. Before you open each one, write down how bad you think it is. After, write how bad it actually was. Watch those two numbers. That's most of what this book has to teach you, and you'll learn it in the first twenty minutes.

DO THIS

- 1 Put the kettle on. Clear the table. Phone on silent, apart from the bank app.
- 2 Gather the last three months of everything on the list below, and tick each one off as it lands on the table.
- 3 Open every envelope and every email you've been avoiding. Score each one before you open it, and again after.
- 4 Don't fix anything yet. Not one thing. Tonight's for looking.

ON THE TABLE

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Bank statements or app history, last three months, every account | ☐ Credit card and store card statements |
| ☐ Loans, overdrafts and any pay-later accounts | ☐ Payslips, invoices or benefit letters: whatever shows what comes in |
| ☐ Bills: rent or mortgage, energy, water, phone, local tax, insurance | ☐ Every unopened envelope and unread email from anyone you pay or owe |
| ☐ A pencil, a rubber, a calculator and a brew | |

The envelopes. Score each one out of ten, where ten is the worst thing you can imagine.

WHO IT'S FROM	WHAT IT TURNED OUT TO BE	HOW BAD?	
		BEFORE	AFTER

What I noticed: _____

The Mains

What comes in, how often, and how steady it really is.

The mains is where the water comes into the house. Before you look for leaks, you want to know what's coming through the pipe, and how steady it is. Some people get one wage on the same day every month. Some get bits from all over. In my trade, overtime and call-outs came in fits and starts, and it took me years to stop counting money I hadn't been paid yet.

So write down what actually landed. Not what you were promised, not what you invoiced, not what you're owed by your brother-in-law. What landed.

DO THIS

- 1 Go through three months of statements and write down every amount that came in: wages, benefits, pensions, side jobs, money from family, refunds.
- 2 Work out the monthly figure for each one. The box below does the sums.
- 3 If it changes from month to month, write down your lowest month as well. Plan on the lowest, not the best.
- 4 Note any money you're counting on that isn't certain yet. Count it when it lands, not before.

What comes in.

WHERE IT COMES FROM	HOW OFTEN	AMOUNT	PER MONTH	STEADY?	
				YES	NO
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
Total coming in per month					

TURNING IT INTO A MONTHLY FIGURE

Weekly

times 52, then divide by 12

Fortnightly

times 26, then divide by 12

Every four weeks

times 13, then divide by 12

My lowest month of the three: _____

Money I'm counting on that isn't certain yet: _____

What I noticed: _____



The Pipework

Everything that goes out on a schedule, whether you look or not.

Pipework is the stuff built into the walls: rent or mortgage, energy, water, phone, insurance, local tax. Nobody thinks about pipes till one goes. But it's where the big money runs, and some of it was put in years ago by somebody who isn't you any more. The phone deal you signed three years back. The insurance that renewed itself while you weren't looking.

Even here, ask the question. For the rent, the answer's yes. For the deal that's quietly crept up, it might not be.

DO THIS

- 1 Take one full month of statements. Find every payment that goes out on a schedule: direct debits, standing orders, card payments that repeat.
- 2 Write each one down with the day it leaves. If it's yearly or quarterly, work out the monthly figure.
- 3 Tick Surprise if you didn't know it was there, or didn't know it was that much.
- 4 Then ask: *Would I buy this again today?* Tick Yes or No.

*Every scheduled payment, and the one question next to it: **Would I buy this again today?***

WHAT IT'S FOR	DAY IT GOES	AMOUNT	PER MONTH	SURPRISE?	AGAIN TODAY?	
					YES	NO
				☐	☐	☐
				☐	☐	☐
				☐	☐	☐
				☐	☐	☐
				☐	☐	☐
				☐	☐	☐
				☐	☐	☐
				☐	☐	☐
				☐	☐	☐
				☐	☐	☐
				☐	☐	☐
Total pipework per month						

What I noticed: _____

The Drips

Subscriptions, memberships, plans, and the free trials that quietly stopped being free.

Right. I've never had a subscription I forgot about, and that's not because I'm clever. I've only ever had about four, and every one of them is in a notebook. Most people have more than they think, and that's not daft, it's design: they're built to be easy to start and easy to forget.

A drip doesn't look like much. Stand and watch a dripping tap and you'll get bored before you get worried. Put a bucket under it overnight, though, and have a look in the morning. This page is the bucket.

DO THIS

- 1 Go through three months of bank and card statements. Some things only charge once a year, so search your emails for "renewal" and "subscription" as well.
- 2 Write down every subscription, membership, app, plan, box or "free trial" that turned into a payment. Even the small ones. Especially the small ones.
- 3 Work out what each one costs in a year. Monthly: times twelve. Weekly: times fifty-two.
- 4 Next to each one, ask one question, and only one: ***Would I buy this again today?*** Not "do I need it?" Not "might I use it?" Tick Yes or No and move on. Every No goes on the No Pile in Step 6.

*Every drip, and the one question next to it: **Would I buy this again today?***

WHAT IT IS	HOW OFTEN	AMOUNT	PER YEAR	LAST USED	AGAIN TODAY?	
					YES	NO
					☐	☐
					☐	☐
					☐	☐
					☐	☐
					☐	☐
					☐	☐
					☐	☐
					☐	☐
					☐	☐
					☐	☐
			<i>Total per year</i>			

How many drips I found: _____ How many got a No: _____

What I noticed: _____

The Small Leaks

The forty little things you don't write down.

It's never the big things that empty you. It's the forty little things you don't write down: the four-quid coffee you don't even remember drinking, the meal deal, the taxi because you were late, because you were tired, because. In March 1987 I spent two pound forty on pasties in one week. I wrote it down, and next to it I wrote: *hungry? No. Bored.*

I'm not going to tell you not to have a coffee. I'm going to ask you to count them.

DO THIS

- 1 Pick your small-leak line. Anything under about the price of a takeaway is a good start. Write yours in below.
- 2 Take one month of statements. For every small spend, put a tally mark in the right row, and add up the money as you go.
- 3 Times each row by twelve. Look at that number for a bit. Don't do anything about it yet.
- 4 Ask the question of each row: ***Would I buy this again today?*** Not every coffee is a leak. The ones you'd happily buy again aren't.

My small-leak line: anything under _____

THE LEAK	TALLY	THIS MONTH	IN A YEAR	AGAIN TODAY?	
				YES	NO
Coffees and hot drinks out				☐	☐
Lunches, meal deals, snacks				☐	☐
Takeaways and delivery				☐	☐
Taxis and "just this once" fares				☐	☐
Corner-shop top-ups				☐	☐
Apps, games and in-app bits				☐	☐
Treats I didn't plan				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
Total					

What I noticed: _____



The No Pile

Every No from Steps 3, 4 and 5, and what you’ll do about each one.

Gather up your Nos. This is where looking turns into a plan. You’re still not fixing, mind. You’re deciding. When I’ve found the leak and the water’s off, I don’t rip the whole bathroom out. I pick the one fitting that’s gone, and I sort that. Then the next one.

And if a No is something you’re fond of, that’s fine. A No doesn’t mean you’ve been daft. It means it’s stopped being worth it, and you’re the only one who gets to say so.

DO THIS

- 1 Copy every No from Steps 3, 4 and 5 onto this page. Biggest first.
- 2 For each one, pick what you’ll do: cancel it, ring and ask for a better price, cut it back, swap it for something cheaper, or wait for the renewal date and write the date down.
- 3 Give each one a “by when”. For anything you’re cancelling, make it this week.
- 4 Tick Done as you go, over the next week or two. Not tonight.

THE NO	WHAT I’LL DO	BY WHEN	A MONTH	DONE
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐

Ringin’ up? Say: “I’m going through my outgoings and this one’s gone up. What’s the best you can do for me?” Then be quiet and let them talk. The quiet does most of the work.

What I noticed: _____

What's Owed

The pressure in the system. Write the scary one first.

Debt's not a moral failing, love. It's a number with a date on it. I know it doesn't feel like that at half eleven at night, but on paper that's all it is, and paper is where you can do something about it.

Write them all down: the cards, the loans, the overdraft, the pay-later ones, the catalogue, what you owe your sister. Write the scary one first and get it over with.

DO THIS

- 1 List everything you owe. If you don't know a figure, write "find out" and find out this week.
- 2 For each one, write the balance, the interest rate if there is one, the minimum payment and the day it's due.
- 3 Tick Behind for anything you've missed a payment on.
- 4 If you're behind on your home, your heating, or anything with a court letter, turn to page 9 today, before anything else.

WHO I OWE, AND WHAT FOR	BALANCE	INTEREST	MINIMUM	DUE	BEHIND?
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
Total					

Which one to pay off first? There are two honest ways of going about it, smallest balance first or highest interest first. Both are explained on page 9. Pick one there. Feeling winded? That's normal. Have a biscuit. The cheap ones are fine.

What I noticed: _____

The Pressure Reading

In at the top, out underneath. What's left is the reading.

Right. This is the gauge. What came in goes at the top, what went out goes underneath, and the difference is the pressure. If it's a minus number, you've not failed. You've found out, and most people never do. If it's a plus number and you still never seem to have any, the answer's somewhere in Steps 3 to 5, and now you know where to look.

DO THIS

- 1 Fill in the reading below, using your last full month.
- 2 Work out "the rest" by taking the four you know away from everything that went out. That's the food shop, fuel, clothes and one-offs.
- 3 Pick your first Sunday and write it in. This Sunday, if you can.
- 4 Then shut the book, put the kettle on and have a sit down. You've done the hard bit.

A What came in last month *(Step 2)*

B Everything that went out last month, all of it

A-B The reading: A take away B, plus or minus

WHERE B WENT

1 The pipework *(Step 3, per month)*

2 The drips *(Step 4, per year, divided by twelve)*

3 The small leaks *(Step 5, this month)*

4 Payments on what's owed *(Step 7, minimums or more)*

5 The rest: B take away 1, 2, 3 and 4

My first Sunday Sums: _____

Calm right now, out of 10: _____

Calm on page 5, before I started: _____

The bit I'm proudest of tonight: _____

The first job this week: _____

What I noticed: _____

Part Two

Ray's Rules

Seven rules from forty-six years under other people's sinks.

"I've got no secret. I've got seven habits and a pencil."

Now then. People ask me what the secret is, and when I tell them there isn't one, they look at me like I'm keeping it back. I'm not. What I've got is seven rules that stuck. One came from old Mr Hargreaves, one from a lady's kitchen ceiling, one from Maureen, and one from a pressure washer I never bought.

None of them need a spreadsheet. All of them need doing more than once.

HOW TO USE THEM

One a week. Read a rule on a Sunday, after your Sunday Sums. Seven weeks, seven rules.

Do the small thing. Every rule ends with "Try it this week": one small job, written in, ticked when it's done.

Keep what suits you. Not every rule fits every life. By week seven you'll know which ones are yours. They're all on the fridge card, page 44.

THE SEVEN RULES

1	Open the Envelope <i>bad news gets dearer in the envelope</i>	20
2	Write It Down <i>the app records it; you notice it</i>	21
3	The Bucket Rule <i>fix it before you replace it</i>	22
4	The Thirty-Day Wait <i>wants wait, needs don't</i>	23
5	The Friday Fish <i>budget for joy, on purpose</i>	24
6	The Cheap Biscuit Rule <i>spend where you notice</i>	25
7	Pay the Future First <i>the first line in the book</i>	26

These are habits, not financial advice. I'm a plumber with a pencil. The honest small print is on page 48.

Open the Envelope

Open it the day it lands. Bad news only gets dearer in the envelope.

THE STORY

In 1988 I went to a job two streets over. The lady said there was a brown patch on her kitchen ceiling, could I have a look. I had a look. There was a drip behind the bath panel upstairs, a little one, a washer, and it had been going the best part of two years. She'd heard it. She'd mentioned it to her husband. They just never took the panel off, because they didn't want to know what was behind it.

A washer in 1986 is pennies and ten minutes. By the time I got there it was two joists, a ceiling and most of a week. Same drip. Same water. The only thing that changed was how long nobody looked.

Money's no different. The letter you leave unopened doesn't sit still. It grows interest, and late fees, and a second letter in a different colour.

HOW IT WORKS

- Give the post one home: a tray, a peg, a corner of the sideboard. Everything lands there and nowhere else.
- Open it the day it comes. If you can't deal with it today, write on the front the day you will, and keep that day.
- Look at the bank app at least once a week, on Sunday if nowhere else. Looking isn't the same as worrying. It's a lot cheaper.
- The one you most want to leave is the one to open first. Same trick as Step 1: score it before, score it after.

THE HONEST BIT

If opening it on your own is too much, open it with someone sat next to you. That still counts. And if what's inside has real teeth, page 9 is where you go next.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

The envelope or email I've been leaving: _____

The day I'll open it: _____

☐

Opened it

Write It Down

Write every penny down. The app records it. Writing it down is how you notice it.

THE STORY

You know about the gas bill. Here's what came after. Maureen put a notebook and a pencil on the kitchen table and said: write it down. All of it. She's the brains. I just write it down. That was January 1983, and I've written down every penny since. There are forty-one notebooks now, in a shoebox in the wardrobe.

Why pencil? Because you get things wrong, and a rubber's cheaper than a new notebook.

Kelly asked me once what I'd grab if the house was on fire. I said Maureen. She said, and then? I said the shoebox. She thought I was joking.

I'm not saying you need forty-one notebooks. I'm saying a record isn't the same as noticing. When you write down two pound forty for pasties, your hand has to do it, and somewhere between the pencil and the paper you think: hang on.

HOW IT WORKS

- One place, every day. A notebook, the notes on your phone, the back of an envelope stuck to the fridge. One place, not three.
- Write it the same day, while you still remember why. "Shop, 6.40" is plenty. You're not writing a diary.
- Don't add it up every night. That's what Sunday's for.

THE HONEST BIT

If you hate writing, photograph every receipt and write them up on Sunday instead. It's slower and you'll miss a few, but your eyes still have to look at every one, and that's the bit that matters.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

Where I'll write it down: _____

Days I wrote it down: ☐ MON ☐ TUE ☐ WED ☐ THU ☐ FRI ☐ SAT ☐ SUN

The Bucket Rule

Fix it before you replace it. And if you can't fix it, borrow it before you buy it.

THE STORY

I've never paid for a car wash. I've got a bucket. That's the whole rule, really, but I'll give you the long version.

The shed at the bottom of our garden is where things go to get fixed instead of replaced. There are jam jars of screws on the shelf, sorted by size, because old Mr Hargreaves, who I was apprenticed to in 1971, said a man who can't find a screw ends up buying a new shelf. He also said a new tap is for people who don't own a washer. That's a bit harsh, but he wasn't wrong.

The van's a 2004. Twenty-two years old, a hundred and ninety-one thousand miles, and she still passes her MOT. She's not pretty. She's paid for.

HOW IT WORKS

- Climb the ladder one rung at a time: **mend it > borrow it > buy it second-hand > buy it new.** Most things stop on the first or second rung.
- Before you replace anything, ask what's actually broken. It's usually one part: a washer, a hinge, a zip, a battery, a fuse.
- Paid for beats pretty. Something that works and is paid for isn't old, love. It's paid off.
- If you can't mend it yourself, someone near you probably can, and for less than new. Ask before you buy.

THE HONEST BIT

Don't mend what can hurt you. Gas, electrics, brakes and anything holding a roof up are jobs for someone qualified, and I say that as a man who's qualified.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

One thing I was going to replace that I'll try to mend, borrow or do without: _____

☐

Tried it

The Thirty-Day Wait

Anything over fifty quid that's a want, not a need, goes on the list and waits thirty days.

THE STORY

There's a list pinned to the shed door. Anything over fifty quid that's a want, not a need, goes on it with the date, and it waits thirty days. If I still want it after thirty days, I buy it. No guilt, no fuss. It's not a punishment. It's a filter.

A pressure washer went on that list in 2012. I've still not got one. I've still got a bucket.

Most things never make it to day thirty. You'd be amazed how badly you can want something on a Tuesday and how little you care by the end of the month. The things that do make it, I buy without a second thought, because I've already had the second thought. And the twenty-ninth.

You'll have seen "buy now, pay later" at the till. It's built to get you past the wait. The wait's the bit that protects you.

HOW IT WORKS

- Pick your line. Mine's fifty quid. Yours might be twenty, or two hundred. Anything over it that's a want goes on the list.
- Write down the day you wanted it and the day that's day thirty. The Shed Door List on page 45 is ready to pin up wherever you'll walk past it.
- On day thirty, ask two things: do I still want it, and can I pay for it outright? Two yeses and it's yours. No guilt, no fuss.
- Needs don't wait. If the boiler goes, you fix the boiler. The list is for wants.

THE HONEST BIT

Thirty days feels like a long time when you first start. If it's too long, start with seven. The wait matters more than the length, and you can stretch it once you've seen it work.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

My line: _____

First thing on my list: _____

☐

It's on the list, with the date

The Friday Fish

Budget for joy, on purpose, every week. A budget with no joy in it doesn't last.

THE STORY

Every Friday, fish and chips. Budgeted, written down, enjoyed. In that order. Maureen and I have had it most Fridays since before the notebooks, and once the notebooks started, it got its own line. It's still got its own line.

I'll be honest with you: it's the most important line in there. Every pipe that carries hot water needs a bit of room to move. Clip it in tight with nowhere to go and it'll creak and tick every time the heating comes on, and one day a joint gives. Money's the same. A budget with no give in it holds for a few weeks, then you crack, spend the lot in one go, and feel worse than before you started.

So you build the give in. You choose it, you write it down, and then you enjoy it properly, because it's planned and it's paid for and nobody can make you feel bad about it. Not even you.

HOW IT WORKS

- Pick your Friday Fish: one small, regular treat you actually look forward to. A takeaway, a film, a coffee you'll remember drinking.
- Give it its own line in Sunday Sums and a fixed amount, and write it down when you spend it.
- Enjoy it properly. Sit down for it. It's not a leak. It's the plan.
- Skint week? Make it smaller, not gone. A bag of chips still counts.

THE HONEST BIT

If your Friday Fish has turned into a Monday, Wednesday and Friday Fish, that's not joy any more. It's a leak with a nice name. Back to once a week, and you'll enjoy it more.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

My Friday Fish: _____ About: _____

☐ Had it, and enjoyed it

The Cheap Biscuit Rule

Spend on the things you notice. Go cheap on the things you don't.

THE STORY

I buy the cheap biscuits. After the second one I can't tell the difference, and by the third I've stopped looking. Maureen can tell the difference, so she buys the nice ones and hides them. I've known where since about 1990. I've never said. That's not a row, love. That's a system.

Kitchen roll, washing-up liquid, tinned tomatoes: I couldn't tell you what's in our cupboard, and that's the point. I've never noticed, so I've never paid extra for it. Same with the coffee you can't remember drinking. You didn't enjoy that either. You just paid for it.

Most money doesn't go on things we love. It goes on things we don't notice. Go cheap on those, and spend properly on the rest.

HOW IT WORKS

- Go round your shopping with one question: would I notice if this were the cheap one? If not, try the cheap one once. Most of the time you'll not go back.
- Then spend on what you do notice, without apologising. Good boots. A proper pillow. The nice biscuits, if you're Maureen.

THE HONEST BIT

Cheap isn't always cheaper. Boots, tools, a mattress, anything you use every day: buy cheap, buy twice. The rule's about what you notice, not about buying the cheapest of everything.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

I'd never notice the cheap one:

I'd notice every time:

☐ Swapped one thing for the cheap one, just to see

Pay the Future First

When money comes in, the first bit goes to the future, before the week gets its hands on it.

THE STORY

Christmas 1990 went on the never-never. We were still paying for it in March, and every payment was for a Christmas we'd already had. So in June 1991 I put an envelope at the back of the kitchen drawer, and every month, before anything else went out, ten pound went in it. That Christmas our Gary got a bike. Sixty-two pound, paid for, done. There's a little star in the margin of that notebook. I don't do stars.

That's the rule. When money comes in, the first line in the book is the future. Before the gas, before the shop, before Friday. Some weeks it was a fiver. Some weeks it was nowt, and I wrote the nowt down. You lag your pipes in October, not when they've frozen.

HOW IT WORKS

- Choose an amount, however small, and make it the first thing out on the day the money lands. A pound counts. The habit matters more than the amount.
- Give it a job: the boiler fund, Christmas, a cushion, what's owed. Money with a job to do tends to sit still.
- What "the future" means is your call. Where you keep it, I'm not telling you. That's not my trade, and be wary of anyone online who's very keen to tell you. The lads in gilets will tell you what to buy. I'm only telling you the order.
- For anything bigger than an envelope, like savings, pensions or investing, get free, impartial guidance first. In the UK that's MoneyHelper. Elsewhere, look for your country's free, impartial money guidance service.

THE HONEST BIT

If there's genuinely nothing to put first this week, put the habit first anyway. Write "Future: nowt" at the top of the page. It keeps the line there, and the week there's something, it'll know where to go.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

My future-first amount: _____ It goes out on: _____

Its job: _____

☐

Paid the future first

Part Three

Sunday Sums

The fifteen-minute ritual. Kept every week, for good.

“Last week’s money, then next week’s money. That’s it. That’s the whole thing.”

Every Sunday after my dinner, I make a brew in the brown teapot, the one with the knitted cosy Maureen’s mother made in 1979, and I sit down with the notebook for fifteen minutes. Maureen does the shopping column. I do the rest. We’ve done it since 1983, and I’ll be honest with you: it’s never once been exciting. It’s never once needed to be.

0 to 1 min	Kettle on. Same chair, same time, same pencil. After Sunday dinner works, because nobody forgets Sunday dinner.
1 to 10 min	Last week’s money. What came in, then what went out, row by row, from the bank app and any receipts. Then the sum: in minus out.
10 to 13 min	Next week’s money. What’s coming: bills, birthdays, the MOT, the Friday Fish, anything on the Shed Door List that reaches day thirty.
13 to 14 min	The checks. Envelopes opened? Any new drips? Have a look at the Shed Door List. Then score your calm out of ten.
14 to 15 min	One line, then shut the book. Write what you noticed, tick the box, and close it. You’re done till next Sunday.

GOOD TO KNOW

Paid monthly, or every four weeks? Either write it in the week it lands, or write a week’s share every Sunday: monthly pay times 12, divided by 52. Pick one and stick to it.

Sunday doesn’t suit? Pick any day you never miss. Sunday’s a name, not a law.

Share money with someone? Split the rows between you. Page 8 has the rest.

After Week 12? You carry on in any cheap notebook. Page 42 shows you how.

One I Did Earlier

Ray's Sunday Sums from last week, copied out of the notebook.

Kelly asked me to fill one of these in, so you could see what it looks like once it's been used. This is last Sunday's, copied out of my notebook and a bit neater than usual. It took twelve minutes, thirteen with the seven on the calculator, which sticks. I had a second brew.

Ray's week

Sunday
27th Sept
☒ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

Came in *what landed, or a week's share* *a week's share, pensions*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>	council tax, gas + elec, water	236.60
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>	Maureen's column ①	68.15
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>	diesel, the van	30.00
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>	paper, a pasty (hungry? yes)	6.20
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>	nowt since 1996 ②	0.00
The future <i>paid first</i>	first, as ever ③	60.00
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>	cod twice, chips, peas	21.40
Anything else	card + a tenner, Lisa's youngest	12.95
Total out		435.30

In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money ④

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish	Fri	21.40
Van MOT (she'll pass)	Thu	54.85
Window cleaner	Tue	8.00
Our Gary's birthday, card + a tenner	Sat	10.00

☒ Every envelope opened
☒ New drips written down
☒ Shed Door List looked at

Calm this week: out of 10 ⑤

What I noticed: Diesel's up again. Walking to the chip shop Friday.

☒ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

- Maureen's column.** Her row, her total, every Sunday since 1983. Split yours however suits your house.
- Owed: nowt.** I still write the line every week. A line with a nought in it is a line you're watching.
- The future.** It sits sixth on the page, but it's the first money out, on the day it lands.
- Next week's money.** The bit most people skip. It's why the MOT on Thursday isn't a surprise.
- Calm: nine.** Nobody's a ten. There's always diesel.

Week 1

Sunday _____

☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

 Came in *what landed, or a week's share*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>		
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>		
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>		
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>		
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>		
The future <i>paid first</i>		
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>		
Anything else		

Total out

 In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened

☐ New drips written down

☐ Shed Door List looked at

 Calm this week: out of 10

What I noticed:

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

Week 2

Sunday _____

☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

 Came in *what landed, or a week's share*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>		
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>		
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>		
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>		
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>		
The future <i>paid first</i>		
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>		
Anything else		

Total out

 In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened

☐ New drips written down

☐ Shed Door List looked at

 Calm this week: out of 10

What I noticed:

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

Week 3

Sunday _____

☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

 Came in *what landed, or a week's share*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>		
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>		
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>		
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>		
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>		
The future <i>paid first</i>		
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>		
Anything else		

Total out

 In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened

☐ New drips written down

☐ Shed Door List looked at

 Calm this week: out of 10

What I noticed:

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

The Boring Bit

A letter for the end of Week 3. Read it before you turn the page.

Now then,

Three Sundays done. I'd put money on it having gone boring by now. The same chair and the same rows as last week. Week one felt like a fresh start. Week three felt like the washing-up.

Good. That's what it's supposed to feel like.

Nobody gets a thrill from bleeding the radiators. You do it because the house stays warm. Sunday Sums is the same. The Leak Hunt was the hard bit, the bit with all the feelings in it. This is maintenance now, and maintenance is meant to be dull. If it was exciting, something would be broken.

Here's what I've seen, forty-odd years of it. Most people stop right here. Not because it's hard. Because it's boring, and they think boring means it isn't working. It means it is. This exact Sunday is the whole game.

So don't add anything this week. Don't make it better, don't buy a new notebook, don't start a spreadsheet. Turn the page and do Week Four. Fifteen minutes. Then the kettle.

Ray

P.S. If you've already missed one, you're in good company. Read page 7, then do this Sunday. Not last Sunday. This one.

BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

Flick back through your first three weeks and copy your calm scores here. Don't judge them. Just look.

Week 1

out of 10

Week 2

out of 10

Week 3

out of 10

Then write down one thing you know now that you didn't know a month ago.

Week 4

Sunday _____

☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

 Came in *what landed, or a week's share*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>		
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>		
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>		
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>		
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>		
The future <i>paid first</i>		
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>		
Anything else		

Total out

 In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened

☐ New drips written down

☐ Shed Door List looked at

 Calm this week: out of 10

What I noticed:

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

Week 5

Sunday _____

☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

 Came in *what landed, or a week's share*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>		
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>		
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>		
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>		
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>		
The future <i>paid first</i>		
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>		
Anything else		

Total out

 In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened

☐ New drips written down

☐ Shed Door List looked at

 Calm this week: out of 10

What I noticed:

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.



Week 6

Sunday _____ ☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

Came in

what landed, or a week's share

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework	anything on a schedule	
The shopping	food and the house	
Getting about	fuel, fares, parking	
Small leaks	the forty little things	
What's owed	payments this week	
The future	paid first	
The Friday Fish	budgeted joy	
Anything else		
Total out		

In minus out

came in, take away total out

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened

☐ New drips written down

☐ Shed Door List looked at

Calm this week:

out of 10

What I noticed: _____

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

Week 7

Sunday _____

☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

Came in *what landed, or a week's share*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>		
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>		
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>		
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>		
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>		
The future <i>paid first</i>		
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>		
Anything else		

Total out

In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened☐ New drips written down☐ Shed Door List looked atCalm this week: out of 10

What I noticed:

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

Week 8

Sunday _____

☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

Came in *what landed, or a week's share*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>		
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>		
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>		
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>		
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>		
The future <i>paid first</i>		
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>		
Anything else		

Total out

In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened☐ New drips written down☐ Shed Door List looked atCalm this week: out of 10

What I noticed: _____

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

Week 9

Sunday _____

☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

Came in *what landed, or a week's share*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>		
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>		
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>		
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>		
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>		
The future <i>paid first</i>		
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>		
Anything else		

Total out

In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened☐ New drips written down☐ Shed Door List looked atCalm this week: out of 10

What I noticed:

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

Week 10

Sunday _____

☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

Came in *what landed, or a week's share*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>		
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>		
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>		
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>		
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>		
The future <i>paid first</i>		
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>		
Anything else		

Total out

In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened☐ New drips written down☐ Shed Door List looked atCalm this week: out of 10

What I noticed: _____

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

Week 11

Sunday _____

☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

 Came in *what landed, or a week's share*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>		
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>		
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>		
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>		
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>		
The future <i>paid first</i>		
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>		
Anything else		

Total out

 In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened

☐ New drips written down

☐ Shed Door List looked at

 Calm this week: out of 10

What I noticed:

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

Week 12

Sunday _____

☐ Kettle on

Last week's money

about ten minutes

 Came in *what landed, or a week's share*

WENT OUT	NOTES	AMOUNT
The pipework <i>anything on a schedule</i>		
The shopping <i>food and the house</i>		
Getting about <i>fuel, fares, parking</i>		
Small leaks <i>the forty little things</i>		
What's owed <i>payments this week</i>		
The future <i>paid first</i>		
The Friday Fish <i>budgeted joy</i>		
Anything else		

Total out

 In minus out *came in, take away total out*

Next week's money

about three minutes

WHAT'S COMING UP	WHICH DAY	AMOUNT
The Friday Fish		

☐ Every envelope opened

☐ New drips written down

☐ Shed Door List looked at

 Calm this week: out of 10

What I noticed:

☐ Sunday Sums done. Shut the book. Kettle's still warm.

Twelve Sundays On

Take the reading again. Then decide what you're keeping.

Right. Turn back to page 5 and copy in your first scores. Then score yourself again, today, the same way. Don't be kind and don't be hard. Be honest, like you were the first time.

OUT OF 10	PAGE 5	TODAY	DIFFERENCE
How calm I feel when I open the bank app			
How well I know where my money goes			
How well I sleep without money on my mind			

My twelve weekly calm scores, copied off each Sunday page:

W1	W2	W3	W4	W5	W6	W7	W8	W9	W10	W11	W12

Now read the note you wrote to yourself on page 5. Whatever the numbers say, that's a reading, not a feeling, and it's twelve weeks of it in your own handwriting. That's evidence.

What I'd say back to the me who wrote that note: _____

THE KEEP LIST: THE BITS THAT WORKED, IN MY WORDS

1

2

3

4

5

Copy these onto the fridge card on page 44.

The date of my first Sunday in my own notebook: _____

The ritual's yours now. Get a plain notebook, the cheap one. Rule it up like these pages: last week's money, then next week's money. Next Sunday is the first of the rest. I'll not be checking. Nobody will. That's the point.

Rich is quiet.

Ray

The Twenty-Minute Leak Hunt

One month, one app, one brew, and a timer.

I'd rather you did twenty minutes tonight than three hours never. This is the Leak Hunt with the engine running. It won't find everything. It'll find enough to make the full sitting feel worth doing.

0 to 2 min **Kettle on.** Open the bank app at last month. Set a timer for twenty minutes.

2 to 8 min **Count what repeats.** Scroll last month and count every payment that comes back: direct debits, subscriptions, anything with the same name twice.

Regular payments: _____ Of those, subscriptions: _____

8 to 12 min **Ask the question.** For every subscription: *Would I buy this again today?*

How many got a No: _____ The biggest No: _____

12 to 16 min **Count one small leak.** Pick one kind, like coffees, takeaways, taxis or snacks, and count them for the month.

My leak: _____ Times: _____ Amount: _____ Times twelve: _____

16 to 18 min **Open one envelope.** The one you've been leaving. Score it before you open it, and again after.

It was: _____ Before: _____ After: _____

18 to 20 min **Book your first Sunday.** Write it in, and put the book somewhere you'll see it.

My first Sunday Sums: _____

The one leak I'm fixing this week: _____

☐

Fixed it

When you're ready, the full Leak Hunt starts on page 10. It'll keep.

The Fridge Card

Print this page, cut along the dashed lines, and stick them where you'll see them.

Sunday Sums

fifteen minutes, with a brew

Last week's money, then next week's money.

- 1 **Kettle on.** Same chair, same time, same pencil.
- 2 **Last week's money.** Came in, went out, in minus out.
- 3 **Next week's money.** What's coming, and the Friday Fish.
- 4 **The checks.** Envelopes, drips, the Shed Door List. Calm, out of ten.
- 5 **One line.** What I noticed. Tick the box. Shut the book.

Missed one? No catching up. Just do this Sunday.

Ray's Rules

and the ones I'm keeping

- 1 **Open the Envelope.** The day it lands.
- 2 **Write It Down.** Writing is noticing.
- 3 **The Bucket Rule.** Mend > borrow > second-hand > new.
- 4 **The Thirty-Day Wait.** Wants over my line wait.
- 5 **The Friday Fish.** Budgeted, written down, enjoyed.
- 6 **The Cheap Biscuit Rule.** Spend where you notice.
- 7 **Pay the Future First.** The first line in the book.

My Keep List

- 1 _____
- 2 _____
- 3 _____
- 4 _____
- 5 _____

THE AGAIN TEST

Would I buy this again today?

Not "do I need it". Not "is it handy". Would I buy it again, today?

THE THIRTY-DAY WAIT

Over _____? On the list.

A want, not a need, waits thirty days. Still want it, and can pay outright? Buy it. No guilt, no fuss.

Cut along the dashed lines. The two small ones fit in a purse or a wallet.

The Shed Door List

The Thirty-Day Wait, ready to pin up. Mine's on the shed door. Yours can go on the fridge.

My line: anything over _____ that's a want, not a need, goes on here and waits thirty days.

Both boxes ticked on day thirty? It's yours, with a clear conscience. Still want it, but can't pay outright yet? Leave it on. Gone off it? Cross it off.

WHAT I WANT	PRICE	WANTED ON	DAY THIRTY	ON DAY THIRTY	
				STILL WANT	CAN PAY
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐
				☐	☐

Cross things off when you stop wanting them. Mine's mostly crossings-out, and that's the point.

Things I've Never Paid For

And a few things I always will. Then yours.

Kelly asked me for this list for the internet. It's not a boast. Some of it's luck, some of it's stubbornness, and some of it's just being a plumber.

NEVER PAID FOR

- **A car wash.** I've got a bucket.
- **Bottled water.** I spent forty-six years making sure the tap works.
- **A new car.** Every car I've owned had somebody else's crisps down the seat first.
- **Interest on a credit card.** If it went on the card, it came off the card that month.
- **A subscription I forgot about.** I've had about four. I could name them all.
- **An extended warranty.** I am the warranty.
- **A plumber.** Obviously.
- **Delivery on a takeaway.** The chip shop's a ten-minute walk. That's the delivery.

ALWAYS PAID FOR, GLADLY

- **Good boots.** My feet have climbed a lot of other people's stairs.
- **Proper tools.** A spanner that slips costs you a knuckle.
- **Fish and chips on a Friday.** You know about that.
- **A card for every grandchild, with a tenner in.** Kelly says it's not kept up with inflation. Kelly can write her own card.
- **The nice biscuits.** Well. Maureen does.

MINE: THINGS I'M DONE PAYING FOR

MINE: THINGS I'LL GLADLY KEEP PAYING FOR

Ray's Notebook, March 1987

Notebook number five, one week of it. Kelly scanned it, and I've written on the side what's what.

	Sun 15th March 87		
	tu	wages	141.20
		Sat o/z	18.00
			38.40
1	Future	5.00	34.85
2	Gas	qtr, pd same day	38.40
3	Shop	(M)	34.85
4	Fishtchips	Fri	2.60
5	Pasties	hungry? No. Bored.	2.40
	Gary	shoes	9.99
	washers	+ olive	0.45
	bus	wk	2.40
	paper		1.20
6	Drill	24.99 30 days	
	OUT		97.29
	LEFT		61.91
	mon	tea bags 32 milk 44 brd 48	
	tue	nails, M's mvm bday card 35	
	wed	bread 48 eggs 62 bus 50	
	thu	fuse wire 29, milk 22	

- Future first.** Five pound, before anything else got a look in. Four years after the gas bill, that line was never missing.
- Gas, paid the day it came.** I never let another one sit on the mantelpiece.
- (M) is Maureen.** She did the shop and told me the total. She still does.
- Fish and chips for two,** two pound sixty. Don't tell Kelly what it costs now.
- The pasties.** I wrote that note to myself in 1987, and I've been asking it ever since.
- A drill, crossed out.** The Thirty-Day Wait before it had a name. Borrowed one off Mr Hargreaves instead.
- Sums in the margin, by hand.** The calculator didn't come till 1989. Took longer. Stuck better.

Notebook five of forty-one. The rest are in the shoebox, in the wardrobe, next to my good shoes.

The Honest Small Print

Written warm, not legal. Read it anyway.

Ray isn't real

Ray is a fictional character, created with AI. There's no Maureen, no shoebox and no van, though there are plenty of real people like them. The voice is made up. The habits aren't: writing it down, looking at it every week, waiting before you buy and planning in a bit of joy are ordinary, old habits that real people have kept for a very long time.

What this book is, and isn't

This book is general information about money habits. It isn't financial advice, debt advice, tax advice or advice about your own situation, and it doesn't recommend any product, provider or investment. It can't promise you'll save any particular amount. If you need advice for your circumstances, use one of the free services below or a qualified, independent adviser.

About the numbers

Ray's figures, prices and dates are made up to make the examples feel real. They're not a guide to what anything should cost, or to what anyone should earn or save.

Free help, if it's serious

Debt and money

UK: MoneyHelper
(moneyhelper.org.uk),
StepChange (stepchange.org),
Citizens Advice
(citizensadvice.org.uk)
US: a nonprofit credit counsellor
through the NFCC (nfcc.org)
Elsewhere: a free, not-for-profit
debt advice service near you

If someone controls your money

UK: National Domestic Abuse
Helpline, 0808 2000 247
US: National Domestic Violence
Hotline, 1-800-799-7233
Elsewhere: your local domestic
abuse service

If you're not coping

UK and Ireland: Samaritans, 116
123
US: call or text 988
Elsewhere: your local crisis line,
or the emergency services if
you're in danger

Good debt advice is free. Be wary of anyone who charges for it, or who rings you first.

That's your lot, love. Kettle's on.